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Newsom signs bills to promote better nutrition in school cafeterias

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Gov. Gavin Newsom signed a suite of bills on Saturday aiming to promote better nutrition in public schools, chiefly by restricting synthetic food dyes linked to health disorders, while also attempting to boost enrollment in state food assistance programs.

The first bill, AB518, is an effort to increase participation in the CalFresh food aid program sponsored by Assembly Member Buffy Wicks, D-Oakland, spokespeople for the governor's office said. The legislation requires state officials to create a plan estimating the CalFresh participation rate by July 2025 and to work to reach Californians who are eligible but not enrolled.

Newsom also signed AB2316, which, starting at the end of 2027, prohibits K-12 public and charter schools from serving food dyes found to cause cancer, immune system damage, neurobehavior issues and hyperactivity. Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, sponsored the bill.

Additionally, the governor signed AB660, which standardizes food safety and quality labels. Assembly Member Jacqui Irwin, D-Encino, sponsored the bill.

Taken together, the bills will make "it possible for everyone, including school kids, to access nutritious, delicious food without harmful, and often addictive additives," Newsom said in a statement. "By giving every child a healthy start, we can set them on the path to a future with less risk of obesity and chronic illness."

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